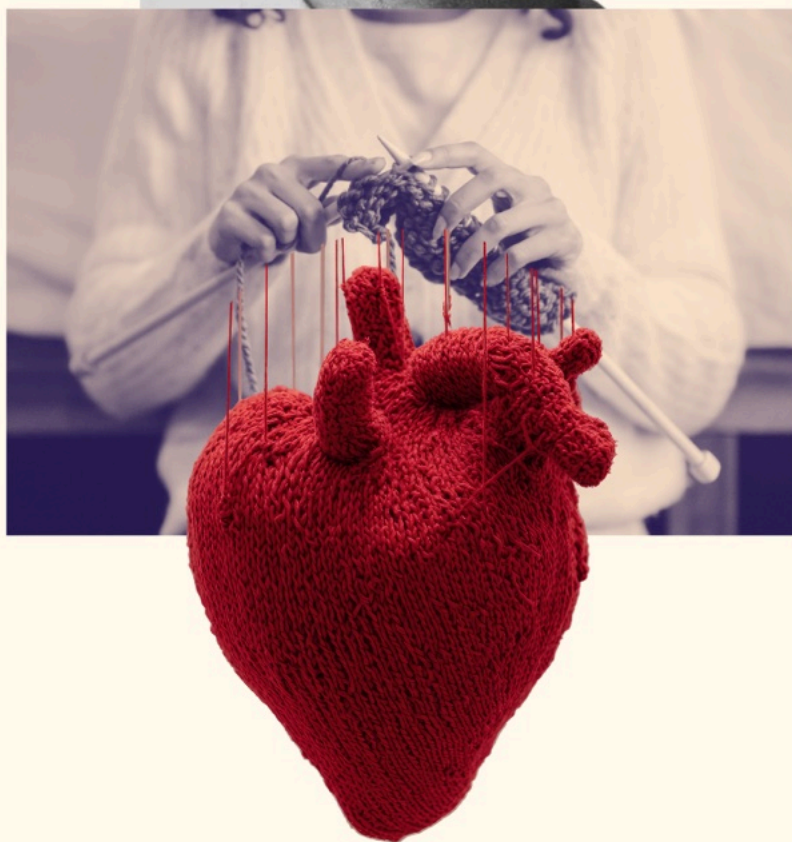


Palimpsest

Capistrano
Catbagan
Martin
Nodora
Oloya



LOVE!SICK!CANNIBAL!
LOVE!SICK!CANNIBAL!

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What do you wish upon a
star?

Supernova

By Caedyn Martin

There have been very few instances where I've felt like the stars have aligned in my life.

The first time was when my Tita Lovely lended me her dusty ukulele, the one laying peacefully at the bottom of her stacked shelves in the living room. Letting my fingers glide over the strings, pressing down on the frets experimentally, then learning my first chord with my Tita's gentle, guiding voice? It was when I realized, at age four, that making music was *for* me. The other times were as follows: my mom getting me a guitar, meeting my best friends in front of the nearest Sari-Sari store to my house, and well, getting close to one of them in particular—Ellen.

I still see it, the toothy grin on her face, back when it was still rather chubby, whenever I'd pull her along despite her parents telling her to finish her stupid homework first. We would chew bubblegum from Tita Bessy's Sari-Sari Store and have picnics on some hill overlooking a lake on one side, and our barangay on the other. One night in particular, we laid down on the grass, soft green blades caressing our limbs, when she took my hand and raised it.

"That's Lyra!" She said then, all with the brightest grin on her face. "My favorite constellation."

"Oh! And that?" I pointed elsewhere.

“Orion!” She guided my hand, tracing it over the stars. “It’s rare that they appear here like this. I only see them together a short time every year.”

Indeed. For right after our own short window of time together, she departed from the province with an Elementary Diploma in hand. Manila, her parents said. I haven’t properly looked at the stars since. I just assumed Lyra and Orion were out of season together all the time.

Now, however, despite the sun still glaring down at me from above, I can feel it. Lyra and Orion are about to meet once more. The stars are, once again, aligning. Passing the talent auditions here at UP to become a music major is the biggest accomplishment of my life thus far, aside from having published my very first mini song album back in senior high school. My phone buzzes.

Ellen Santos

HII MATTHEA! I’m here at Sunken Garden. I dyed my hair blonde recently, so it should be easy to spot me :)

The smile on my face couldn’t have spread any wider. I type back how I’m going to squeeze her to death when I finally get to hug her again, hit send, and giggle to myself. My feet begin moving faster on their own, crunching leaves beneath the soles of my shoes with reckless abandon. I reach Sunken Garden just when *Best Friend* by Jason Chen fades out in my wired plastic earphones. I pluck them out before Spotify

could give me an ad, then let them hang and sway in the soft breeze. My head whips from side to side in hopes of letting me spot her, when—

Someone taps my back. “Hey.”

I pivot on my feet with my heels inching above the ground, and when my eyes finally lay on the face of a woman I’ve only seen on her 2 year-old Facebook profile picture, I scream, “Ellen!”

She laughs and says something about how my noisy voice hasn’t changed, and as promised, I lunge towards her and wrap my arms around her. She yelps a little but continues laughing. My face finds the top of her head, and against my nose is the scent of lavender shampoo on soft, warm, slightly damp hair. “You’ve gotten so tall, wow,” Ellen says in between her laughter. I feel her hands come up on my back to pat it, just like when she used to comfort me as kids. My cheeks hurt from smiling so much. “Ugh, and you still hug like you’re trying to kill me,” she says, strained.

“And you...” I pause, pulling back just enough to really look at her. Her outfit is nowhere near as dorky as the HelloKitty-patterned dresses or the old Barbie shirts she would wear (she hated them, but her mother kept getting them for her anyway). Now, she dons a sleek sleeveless top, a black asymmetrical skirt, and a pricey looking purse resting on her waist. My National Bookstore-bought mini backpack shrinks against my spine. “—look like your parents’ business has been doing well.” It *is* what they moved to Manila for, anyway.

Ellen rolls her eyes and sighs. “Mom gets on my ass if I don’t dress like this.”

“You’re pretty.”

Ellen blinks up at me. Somehow, I’ve never felt this nervous and antsy before. I *never* get nervous around people! Ellen, most especially. Still, I clear my throat.

“I—yeah! Your outfit, makeup, and all! Very pretty.”

“Thanks.” She swipes at a leaf that managed to sneak its way into my hair. “I like your outfit, too. It seems you finally grew taste.”

I chuckle. “So? Let’s go? My schedule today’s pretty light since it’s just orientation after orientation.”

“Sure. I’ll pay for lunch.”

“Yeah, you better!” I take her wrist and grin. “Fair warning: I’m going to be dragging you to hangout whenever I can, now.”

Ellen snorts. “Wouldn’t expect anything less.”

Lunch earlier was everything I hoped it would be after reuniting with Ellen. It was like we were back to hanging out at Lola Nesa’s *Karinderya* with tiny feet that couldn’t even reach the ground. She invited me to study with her at cafes, and go out for karaoke on the weekends.

We spend nearly every day eating together for lunch or dinner, now. Obviously, I can’t let Ellen pay for my meals all the time (despite her arguing she can). I would suggest eating at these cheap eateries that serve the *best* sizzling sisig on the campus, so she would concede on letting me pull out my own wallet. Many times, I would catch myself spacing out with my gaze trained on her face whenever we’d sit across

each other. Ellen would grumble my name and snap her fingers until I blinked out of my little stupor. She even invited me to apply to the UP Astronomical Society with her, which I accepted without a second thought. It finally feels like I can watch the stars again, after all.

Never has my stomach churned like this, and yet, my gut somewhat already knows what this wild cluster of feelings is. In my ears plays the same sappy tunes and lyrics I used to listen to over the radio before Spotify ever became a thing (or at least, became popular). Yes, Moira Dela Torre, I hear you. I may be, just a little bit, *torete*. I smile while the chorus plays, and my thumb rubs over my phone screen. My gaze flickers between my and Ellen's smiles on the selfies we took earlier. I hugged my pillow a little tighter that night.

After about a month as freshmen here at UP, we have settled on a rhythm. We know each other's schedules like the back of our hands, now, and not a single food stall or eatery here on the campus has gone unvisited by us. Today, we decided to eat at our favorite cafe in Area 2 since they just introduced a new item to their menu, and I just *knew* I had to taste it. I had just emerged from class, my guitar safely stored in a case strapped against my back, as I wade through the sea of students in this small food street.

With a skip in my step, I reach the cafe, slide open the glass door, and call out, "Ellen—"

"Thanks, Nate. Uh, I'll see if I'm free later, yeah," Ellen says. In front of her is a small bouquet of red roses. Standing next to

her—our—table, is a well-dressed guy who looks to be our age. No, he is probably a little older, perhaps a senior? He's also wearing a UP ID lace. He gives off the air of being from a rich family, sort of like Ellen now. My feet stay planted on the ground by the doorway.

“Great. It'll be fun, I promise. Just a light dinner,” the guy says as he leans with an arm against her table. “I'll let Tita know?”

Ellen nods. “I'll let you know if I'm available later.”

“Uh, excuse me,” a woman murmurs over to me. I snap out of it, mumble an apology, and step aside from the doorway. When I glance back over to Ellen's table, she's already looking right at me with a raised hand.

“Matthea,” she greets, giving me a wave.

“Hey,” I say with a grin a bit too crooked. I approach, dodge a few tables and standing customers, nod with an awkward glance at this Nate guy who's also now looking at me, then sit across from Ellen.

He jokingly introduces himself as Ellen's ‘future boyfriend’, to which Ellen unsurprisingly gives him her signature glare. I force a laugh and try to ignore the way my heart detaches from its veins and drops straight into my stomach. My fingers twitch against my lap. I give my name to the guy, and after a few long, winding minutes of small talk, bid him farewell since he needed to catch his next class. When I turn to Ellen, the bouquet is no longer on the table, and is sitting still beside her. I clear my throat and she looks at me.

“So, who exactly is Nate?” I say, tapping my fork against the table. There is a incessant pounding in my ears.

“Ah, some guy my mom introduced me to. She said his family was rich, and well, if we managed to get a business partnership with them, it could do well for us.”

“Business partnership.”

Ellen sighs. “I agreed to let him court me to keep the peace at home. Mom and dad both wanted me to. I just met him last week, and he began courting me literally the day after, so...”

“So... You don’t like him?”

She shrugs. I can’t read her face. “He’s nice. Sweet, even. I don’t know, I guess we’ll see.”

Later, the moment I boarded the jeepney enroute to SM North (since my apartment is a short walk from there), I must have mentally blacked out. The rocking of the jeep, the sensation of passengers accidentally knocking against me, the faint stench of a deodorant-less man beside me—all of this, I did not even notice until about 10 seconds before I was supposed to get off. My brain rewound the sight of those velvet roses again and again. Then it would jump to the image of that guy—Nate—and Ellen kissing. Going on dates. Getting married. Bile and acid had crept up my throat.

That night, after getting settled for bed, my eyes cried their first star tear. It didn’t just stop there, either.

It hurts. I can barely open my eyes without feeling my nerves burst into flames. Everything burns too brightly now that I keep crying. All I see is her through the blinding rays. I don’t even understand why I

weep this much. It was never meant to be, and I knew that. We're both girls. Her parents would never—*she* would never...

It's like I've been demoted, and someone else has taken my place. Every beat of my heart is accompanied by the chime of metal clattering down onto my thighs. The light stains my blanket, my cheeks, and marks itself on them. It's fine. I'll just have to scrub these in the morning.

I drag myself to the hospital the next day.

"Star Tears Disease, an ancient ailment born out of perceived unrequited love," the doctor said. *"You should tell your beloved,"* she added. *"For them to return their love is the only cure."*

"I can't. She—they won't, uhm... They aren't like me."

"... I'm sorry."

"Is there really no other way?"

"Surgery is an option, dear. It isn't a complicated procedure, either. However, removing these stars from your system will permanently remove your present feelings, and the future potential of them, for this person. If you truly won't ask them, it is best decide before you go truly blind."

The conversation loops in my ears. It had been hours since I sat in that cold room, staring down posters about proper hygiene on the walls of my physician's office. I could still read them clearly at that point, though it is only a matter of time—half a year, she said—until I would no longer be able to. That aside, I am home now, safe under the

warmth of my blanket, yet the galaxy continues to spill from my eyes. With each slip of a tiny star from my tear ducts, an electric hot sensation stings. I will myself to stop, but the chiming and clattering of these tears continue.

My dorm room, come dawn, resembles Andromeda. When I blink my eyes open that morning, the flower vase on the other side of my room starts looking rather fuzzy.

I text Ellen that night:

Matthea Wenceslao

hi :) im sick rn. i cant come tomorrow. rain check?

Something is up with Matthea. I'm certain she's hiding something from me, and it pisses me the fuck off. I know her. I've spent my entire childhood with her, and if there's one thing I'm sure of, it's that she's horrible at lying or just flat out pretending. She never even needed to, at least not with me. Have the numerous times I've knocked that into her head back then, that whatever she's going through, it's safe with me—not mean anything to her anymore? Her smiles have been strained recently. Dimmed, as one would say. She still goes out to lunch with me, especially when our schedules align, but she doesn't text me first anymore about it, like usual. Hell, I've been making sure I now go out of my way and go to her building just to catch her for lunch, because

otherwise, there wouldn't *be* a lunch out. Forget our cafe study sessions, too. Apparently, she needs a more quiet space to focus.

At first, I didn't say anything—which is unlike me, I know. This awkwardness is still infinitely better than causing Matthea to shrink back even further, which is a bigger headache to deal with. I take note of everything she does and doesn't do whenever we *do* hang out. How could I not? As frustrated as I am, I need to make sure she's still at least a little okay. Plus, I'm not stupid. Whatever she's going through, it's about me. She still talks in that adorably obnoxious way of hers towards her other friends. I am the exception. The only reason why I haven't blown up on her about it yet is because I know damn well I haven't done anything to hurt her. If she doesn't come to me about her issues soon, *then* I'll talk to her.

What I have noticed, however, is that over the next few weeks, Matthea has been struggling to see clearly. I thought she ignored me at a hallway two times because of this. So, the next time we went to the mall, I took her to an Executive Optical shop and got her glasses as an advanced gift for her birthday next week. What shocked me was how terrible her vision already was, when she could spot me from the other side of Sunken Garden back at the start of this academic year. Anyhow, I thought that this gift would break the ice, and yet, her distance is still palpable days after that.

Enough is enough.

About four days before her birthday, I go up to the exit of Matthea's classroom for her final period today. When she emerges from the room, I grasp her hand and begin dragging her towards the lobby of Palma Hall despite her confused protests. I find a secluded spot outside, just around AS Steps, and there I finally ask the question: *Why have you been avoiding me?*

She denies it, obviously. I keep pressing. Again and again, until she breaks, because I'm tired of us being like this. I want to be close to her, and I want her to be close to me, without it feeling forced. We've finally met and intersected, and yet, it is like Lyra and Orion are still on opposite night skies. When she steps back, I step after her. When she pulls her hand away, I take it again—gripping harder.

Finally, I say, "Do you even want to be friends with me? You're treating me like I'm some kind of disease!"

Matthea with wildly furrowed eyebrows and tense shoulders, then counters with, "Maybe I don't! Maybe I've been putting up with you all this time because I thought you were still the same Ellen I knew back then, when the truth is you aren't!" Her voice begins to crack. "So do me a favor and just stay away from me!"

I stood there, feet heavy, with my lungs expanding and contracting like crazy, when I see it. There, right there, clear as day—a shimmering tear in the shape of a five-pointed star escapes her eye with a chime, then clatters onto the ground.

My heart drops. Before I could say anything else, she takes off. I stand there in place, watching her shrinking back, then glancing back down onto the radiant tear on the ground.

I sit on a bench overlooking the vastness of Sunken Garden, replaying the moment Matthea and I met again. It's been a day since we fought. Neither of us have sent a message since. I hunch forward, both elbows digging into the flesh of my thighs as I cup my cheeks with my hands. Beside me, I hear a light rustling of fabric and a backpack. A few leaves are scraped off the bench. I see Nate's blue jacket in the corner of my eye.

"You've been moping for a while now," Nate says quietly. He hands me a bottle of water.

"Mm." I accept it. When I twist the cap, it's already been pre-opened. I mumble a thanks then drink from it.

"Come on, out with it. Is it Matthea?"

I grasp my own arms. "The hell do you mean? Matthea? Why do you always ask about her?"

He hums, then sighs. "So it is."

"Shut up."

"Her birthday is in two days, you know? If you fight, who is she going to spend her day with?"

"She has other friends."

"Mhm."

Silence lingers between us. I hate it. He's right, he knows he is, and he knows I know. Nate has been like a mirror to me the entire time we've gotten to know each other, really. It's a little uncomfortable, but not once has he made fun of me for any ugliness he's seen in me, whether appearance-wise or personality-wise. I squeeze my arms. A minute of silence more, and I can't hold it in anymore.

"I just, I can't fucking tell what made Matthea avoid me like this! Like, *yes* she still hangs out with me, *yes* she still talks to me, but it's obvious. It's so obvious. Why won't she just talk to me properly about it? We're both adults, and yet, she just claims she doesn't want to be friends anymore! I've done everything for us to be close friends—*best friends* again. Fuck! If I had the choice, I wouldn't have moved here before college. I would have stayed there, continued growing up with her, and—and everything. What did I do? How did I fuck up? I can't let her keep going like this. She's my friend. I can't lose her."

"Ellen."

"*What.*"

"You like her. Matthea." I pause, glancing back at Nate. His eyes scream 'resigned'. "Just say it how it is. It's obvious, you know."

"..."

Is that what this is all this time, then? I like Matthea? I have never exactly known what it means to like someone before. It's kind of why none of the boys my parents have introduced me to have ever made it past the courting stage with me. Nate must have noticed how dodgy I've been with him, then. Well, all the others before him certainly did.

Unlike the others, though, who all picked fights with me or clung too desperately, Nate continued sticking around without ever crossing boundaries. Actually, now that I think about it, he hasn't been giving me flowers anymore, and yet, he's still cordial. Friendly. Relief surges through my veins. A huff.

The next image I see in my head is Matthea's face—the crooked teeth making up her goofy smile, her sharp nose that makes people question whether she really is Filipino or not, and her kind eyes. God, her eyes. The lone star tear enters my mind again. That star—was it a wish for me?

I have never once feared the thought of losing someone. And yet, when it comes to her...

“... I do like her.”

Unexpectedly, Nate turns towards me and smiles. He elbows my arm. “Then go get her.”

Two days pass and I have been nothing but a bundle of nerves and anxiety.

I take five seconds to take in a deep breath, hold for two, then exhale for seven, just as my counselor once taught me. In my slightly trembling hands is a small box of cake fit for two people. The cake inside is chocolate, Matthea's favorite, and in the shape of a heart. Earlier, I borrowed the baker's piping bag to write the message myself. *Happy 19th birthday, you absolutely adorable idiot*, it says in light blue icing. Again, her favorite. I adjust my grip, holding the box in one hand,

as I pull out the key copy Matthea gave me weeks ago because ‘*I wouldn’t mind you dropping by whenever you wanted.*’ I unlock the door, nudge it open with my foot, then freeze.

The entire floor is covered in glowing stars, constellations formed by the very wishes cast upon them. I rush inside, shut the door, and put the cake on a table before beelining towards the curled up Matthea on her bed. She’s sniffing. She tenses up beneath her blanket even when she hasn’t seen who it was who entered.

“Go away,” she mutters, her words almost rendered incoherent by her spasmed breaths.

I don’t listen to her. I sit on the edge of the bed, take my shoes off, then shift towards her. My eyes grow watery as I reach down to hug the big Matthea-shaped lump under that fluffy blue blanket. I stay like that for a long time, just hugging her, and after her hyperventilating subsides, I whisper, “Happy Birthday.”

“Why did you still come?” Her voice is muffled.

“Because we’re best friends.”

“... You wouldn’t want to keep being best friends with me,” she whispers beneath the blanket.

I purse my lips. I exhale through my nostrils. “Why do you think that?”

“I’m different. You’re different... from me. We can’t be friends. Not anymore. *So, please, El.*”

My impatience takes over. I peel the blanket off her, revealing her tense, quivering body. Still, I tug her up by the arm, supporting her

back along the way, then pull her against me. I wrap my arms around her and keep her here. “I’m sorry, Matthea.”

“Why are you—” She sniffles against my shoulder. I can feel the warmth of her glowing tears and the coolness of her snot on my skin, and I’ve never felt more comfortable. “—the one apologizing? I was the one who... pushed you away.”

“No, it’s okay. I get it.”

“No, you don’t—”

“Mat.”

I pull back slightly and reach out a hand. My fingers touch the stardust-stained cheeks of Matthea’s for the first time, and my thumb glides against the streaks of glowing dust. It’s a beautiful sight. Mat is a beautiful sight. I cup the side of her face, and the way she leans against my hand so easily almost makes me giggle. This, I can tell, is not pretend. “Huh?” She murmurs.

“I like you.” I take in the way she blinks once, then effectively bluescreens. I chuckle. “Romantically. There, no more room for misinterpretation. Do you get it? This is why I’m never going to listen to you when you tell me to go away.”

Matthea blinks. Seconds later, a few more tears escape her cloudy eyes, but this time, they no longer glow bright yellow. “You do?”

I nod, smile, then take her hand and press my lips against her knuckles. “I do, so stop crying already, you big baby.”

Silence follows us for a moment, but when I hear Matthea’s silent laugh escape her, I can’t help but smile wider. She’s still crying,

but her tears—they're no longer glowing. They're no longer 5-pointed, either. I yelp as I'm pulled back in for another hug. I squeeze back to let her know that I want this as much as she does.

“Happy birthday, Mat.”

“Thank you,” she whispers.

“Cake here? Or do you want to go out?”

“Let me hold my birthday gift for now.”

“Okay.”



"Woof! Ruff! Bark! *slobber*"



"Will you love me yet?"

would you rather be loved by a performative poet in
a dog cage or not loved at all

By Nicolette Catbagan

i would write a bad poem
hover my fingers
over the keyboard
as i lay on my bed thinking
man fuck this shit
i would write a bad poem
secretly hoping
that the bad poem
would be a good poem
and that the bad poem
would get eight likes on instagram
eight people tapping heart
like they're feeding a stray

now this bad poem
would be about sofie
who walks her dog everyday
at five in the morning
passing outside my window twice
the first time: walking towards the park
the second time: back home
sometimes her doggy would take a shit
right outside my window
and when that happens
she'll linger a bit longer
to pick up his *tubol*
and ill think

doggy, you bitchass motherfucker
i knew you had my back

i know her schedule
better than my own
i also know
that sofie likes poems,
follows lang leav on instagram,
and religiously likes all her posts
never more than
seven minutes after its posted
and from my bedroom window
adjacent to hers
i'd peek at night to see her
sitting by the windowsill
crying at quotes on pinterest
signed by a poet called rumi

so i took a class
deconstructing a poem 101
to write a bad poem
(that's secretly a good poem)
they said to pick one image
and never let it go
so mine would be a leash
"sofie holds the leash tight
and im the dog drooling over her"
nyehehehe
NO
no no no...No-vember
it is '*Almost November*'
like the title

of that one lang leav poem
i should plagiarize that
or ask ai
'hey ai write a lang leav poem
about this girl named sofie
because i can only write bad poems
calling themself bad poems
like it'd make it any less true'
ai says
'poor you, let's try a cage this time'

i sit in a dog cage sighing to myself watching helplessly as dogs are
walked by their owners

i'm an almost teenage labrador sitting inside a fido classic 24'

~~because my owner is broke as hell~~
~~i go ruff ruff~~
~~only once everyday~~

waiting for that split second moment where sofie walks pass and she
shoots me a smile, '*cute dog*'

leaving me hoping that the day would come where she would finally hear
me say

~~some cheesy ass shit like~~

i love you



Frangar, non Frectar

tipid tips

By Nicolette Catbagan

its forty degrees outside
i stand underneath a billboard
while aggressively fanning myself
with my broken handfan
that i told my friends
is better than a jisulife
which in reality
i just can't afford
i read an article once that said
repeatedly chewing inhibits hunger
so i blow the third bubblegum
i've had since this morning
yakee—because doublemints
have also become victims of shrinkflation

i look up at the billboard
i've taken shade under
a banner of a presidential candidate
affectionately nicknamed dong dong
underneath it says
*"dong dong for the filipino people!
dong dong for change!
dong dong for reform!"*
with a speaker on it repeatedly playing
dong dong dong in the tune of baby shark
where right above his heavily airbrushed photo
is a giant veiny dick
in red pentel pen

underneath the shade
i do the mental math
if i commute it would cost me
around sixty pesos on a jeepney
ninety on a train
and free if i walk through this scorching heat
for thirty minutes
so i could have the money
to spend seventy pesos on siomai rice
and enough money to commute back home

i shift my bag as i take a step forward
inside is my iPad 6th generation tablet
a heavy nine inch block of capitalist irony
that my mother just begged off my OFW aunt
given to me in exchange
of *inay* cleaning the house she left

i see my campus in the horizon,
poopy biliman
where my course tells me
 i stand on moving plates
 structurally destructive and constructive
 --beautifully shattering everyday
 to reshape the world i live in
 i climb mountains
 to find stories in rocks and dirt
 just to return to campus
 and have my classmate
 (*a physics major*)
 ask if i've ever tasted coprolite
 i stare at the rocks i've brought home

from outcrops visited
by hundreds of students before me
who dreamt, fought, and endured
but also
cried over Math 2X
and believed that bio > chem labs
just because the institute of biology
has better airconditioning
students who sat on the couches
of their old worn down *tambayans*
having filled the space with laughter
along with vile shittalking

then my peers tell me
i live in a society
plagued by injustices
that i can't stand by and watch idly
and those that dreamt
and fought, and endured
are now lying in coffins
grieved by those like us
who are left to wonder
when we're next

i stand on this plates' surface
underneath the scorching heat
sending a chat to my friends

*'save me a seat, i'll be late
walang jeep'*

*'wala bes
kinuha na ni Coprolite upuan mo'*

i heave a sigh
its easier than screaming

A black and white photograph of a church interior, viewed from the front of the sanctuary looking back down the nave. The architecture features high vaulted ceilings, arched windows, and rows of pews on either side. In the center of the nave, a large, ornate chandelier hangs from the ceiling. Instead of traditional lights, the chandelier contains a bright blue, glowing face with closed eyes and a serene expression. The face appears to be part of the chandelier's structure, with some blue liquid-like drips visible below it. The word "JOY" is superimposed in a large, bold, blue sans-serif font across the lower half of the image, centered horizontally and partially overlapping the pews and the base of the chandelier.

JOY

FLESHBREAD

By Irene Claire Nodora

It will be my first time witnessing it. When Jesus came back to us they cast a net over Him and caught Him midair. No one saw Him again until the third day, where he appeared on TV fused with the cross in front of the new Vatican. He was biologically pure, pulsating, fleshy, and approved by the FDA. Like His love, He was ever-growing and eternal, as shown live from when they cut off a gland from a distal side of Him and it regenerated back again in an instant. There was a poor and paraplegic man sitting next to the overgrown cross. He was chosen among the crowd of churchgoers to be the first to eat Him. With a golden spoon, a cardinal fed him the flesh. And the man ate it with glee. But before I saw what happened next, the cameras went static. There were no videos or pictures of the aftermath anywhere but whatever happened must have gone so well that the following day, everyone started dialing the station. And if it wasn't the station then it was the Vatican. After a silent week, the station finally signed back on. *There's a piece for all of us*; a man claiming to be a 'representative' says.

Starting tomorrow, fleshbread will be sold to churches per kilo.

It had only been today that I got ahold of my local parish's telephone number. I haven't been able to get out of the house because of my ill mother. It was hard to scrap up a decent amount of money for an order. All the money I saved up was eaten up by treatments in efforts to keep her alive. My nursing degree could only do so much. But if this works out like I was told it does, tomorrow I might be able to come back.

It was hard to prepare the flesh. The kitchen knife could barely cut the skin. I put more strength into it. I was then able to section off what seems to be a knuckle-like bulb. I looked closer at my cut. There was an

abnormal marrow structure at the 'core'. Before the flesh regrew again, I saw for a moment the cross section of the rest of the body. It was spongy. A bone growing out of control. Some of them poked through the epidermis, as if it was trying to rebuild itself into the leg that it used to be. It was warm. It was 'breathing'. It was real. It was alive.

My mother was in the other room. She was awake but remained silent. It didn't concern me. That meant that the painkillers she took this morning still worked. I had a glass of water in one hand and a plate of fleshbread in the other. She didn't seem to notice me coming in nor care about me putting the raw meat in between her lips. It was as if, in her faint lucidity, she had understood what was to come and accepted it wholeheartedly. She was able to swallow it without water. It made me step back. Not long after a whistling sound was coming out from her trachea. At first I thought she had choked on it; the lump of flesh was sticking out from her thin throat. But before I could even do anything about it, the lump had already disappeared. It deflated as if it was absorbed. Now, it is said in passing that the time when the blessing takes effect differs per person. The brother who delivered the meat to me said that I must be here for the entirety of the process no matter what or how long. *It is important that I must be a witness.*

I was skeptical during the first hour. What if this was not real? What if the fleshbread that was given to me is but a fake promise sold to someone desperate and poor? My mother could have asked the same question. She did not move. She did not breathe. She did not blink. She had the blank stare of someone very deep in thought. It was a slow wait. It was only when the second hour hit that something peculiar had happened. She was moving her jaw: Mindlessly going up and down. Like a suffocating fish. I haven't seen her do that before. Was it because I was silently praying? I don't know. But it felt like a good sign.

I was now anticipating the third hour. But even as I kept my eyes peeled, the new hour had given nothing but the constant motions of her jaw, now looking like she was a broken machine. She kept doing it until the fourth. Then the fifth. I thought this was the extent of my bought miracle. For a few moments my faith wavered. But then just as the sixth hour came, she started speaking, though neither in English nor in dialect. I couldn't even tell if it was even a language. She had sunken down her bed and had been spouting sounds of an ancient, holocenic tongue. Her sounds barely synchronized with the up and down motion of her jaws. It was at this point that every phenomenon couldn't be marked by the hour. Seconds after her new voice, she began to slowly assimilate with the wood. Bits of her body were filling in the cracks of the old bed frame. I didn't know what to feel. But the more I saw her skin shift around, the more relaxed and joyous I felt. I understood what it was to be a witness. I sat back down. After she was rearranged to the proper form, the stretched skin draping down the bed had begun to grow roots on the floorboard. When I looked and inspected the new appendages, I noticed they were made of cardiac tissue. And they were swelling very rapidly once they had burrowed on the rotting wood. Her head was still intact and in the right place despite it all. The roots throbbed to her gut for the first time. She clears her throat and then calls my name in a way I never knew could be called. *Are you happy with what you are seeing?* She asks and I return with a strong nod. *I am happy. The pure flesh. It is pushing me through His embrace. Please bring more to me. Bring Him to me in his purest.* Before I knew it, I found myself returning back to her room with the entire fleshbread on my arms. As if I knew it by instinct, I placed it on a stretched hollow organ to her lateral side that used to be her stomach. Her flesh multiplied and digested the bread. Her entire body then, save from her intact head, began pulsating and oscillating vibrations I couldn't even process. But I knew that I was being loved for what I have done. She gave birth to new limbs using the marrow-rich meat her body consumed. I can't fathom my own happiness. Joy. Joy. Joy. I called the

church again and bought myself another mound. This time I took it upon myself to buy the best and heaviest kind: The sample derived from the offals. I became indebted but it didn't matter for I am blessed to be a witness. The instant the flesh came into my arms I broke apart it by hand and fed it to my mother. She grew bigger. She oscillated. I am so happy.

It has been 33 hours since I fed her the first bite. I had not slept. I have not eaten. I have not bathed. She was all over the walls and on the wires and on the ceiling and on the floor. At this point, I could not recognize her— no, I recognized and saw her face in every centimeter of flesh that covers the room. The roots were pumping to the main body. I could see the last unmodified part of her from here. It was the most important part of this process. Her ribs and her heart were there and I could see its subtle movements akin to a cocoon. This was it. This is the prayer that I had been waiting for. It was here. I began to cry and weep. I have witnessed His love and she put herself through all of it. Her jaw began to open and close once more, now rapidly as if to breathe in every ounce of oxygen in the air around her.

Joy.

Joy.

Joy.

Joy.

I feel it blossom from my gut. The ribs began to split open and a primal saint emerged from the sternum of what used to be my mother. That split moment of momentary witness, I felt removed from everything. I was rewarded. To witness is to sacrifice. To sacrifice is to buy salvation. To buy salvation is to become



Child of God

By Irene Claire Nodora

“Marian! Call ‘dem parish priests!”

It was the dead of night when he awoke to the most inhuman screech imaginable. Jo, the captain, was the first one to rise and had been standing by its side until the sun’s bald crown began poking through the paddies. The patch of land where he stood was not a stranger to him. Nor was this patch of land unfamiliar with the gait of his callused feet. He and Death Row Acre— that’s what they called this bloody patch of land— were like soulmates bound to the holy promise of flesh.

Death Row Acre was bald unlike the rest of this town. Its soil didn't even look like soil. It was tinted red. Rusting from all that ‘iron’ seeping deep into it. See, this forsaken acre sat right next to a highway. It was a long stretch of concrete where trucks make their way through city to city before the sun rises. It intruded itself over rural lands that wanted none of this. Yet they still accepted the change. They used to call that road ‘Death Row’. Like how the locals called the acre that sat next to it. But some liked the name ‘Road Kill’ more: Double entendre. Then Road Kill as an unofficial official name stuck to everyone. Then roadkill became part of their lives. Then the people themselves were inseparable from the name.

The captain had been standing by the Death Row Strip since he heard the screech. This shouldn’t be the case. Before dawn, if anything hits the strip of land north he’d be the first to clean it up. Especially during summer where the foul smell starts swelling up faster. Marian, his sister and this town’s only seamstress, had come looking for him but he had been waiting for her to come here all night. He called her name a second time the moment he caught a glimpse of that old face; *“Marian! Over*

here. Now!” Now, despite being Jo’s fraternal twin, she wasn’t born with the power to read his mind, despite common belief. Naturally, she got curious. She ran up there, faster, with more power in her steps, thinking she’d see the desecrated body of a holy man only for it to be true in the most vile way possible.

That was the first time someone in Road Kill had gagged in years.

See, when a man or woman has been living near Death Row Strip, nothing would surprise them anymore. And there comes a point in a Road Killer’s life where they could tell how and what had gone and died in this ditch by just a quick look at the bits and trails. Better if there’s fur or skin. But this one was nothing like they’ve ever seen before. Explains that hellish scream last night. And it was mostly intact, too. Though its eyes had popped out and its bowels completely crushed, everything else was kept well preserved like the Holy Spirit had jumped in at the last minute. Its strange nail-hoof legs, polycoric 7-eyed face, tumored head and an unmistakable sheep-like head all lay there clean as if the Lord had intended it.

Now when the priests arrived and finally got to it they couldn’t believe their eyes either. They had to open the sacred texts on the spot and look back and forth between them and the strange cadaver like one of those crazy science men. It took the priests about an hour to decide what to tell Jo and his shaken sister. But Jo had come semi-prepared. He had been brushing up on the word of the Lord and something tells him that this severed lamb might be who he thought it was. *“Lay it on me Father.”* Jo was the first to speak

“Tell me if that thing right ‘ere’s Jesus.”

The men in their robes exchanged glances. They couldn't give Captain a straight answer. But the eldest priest stepped forward and put a hand on Jo's shoulder, spoke; "Take good care of His body. Adorn it if you could. Maybe we'll be forgiven if we do."

And that was it.

The sun got hot by the time the priests left them and it got the captain worried about the rot. Jo told his sister to come get her sewing kit so that they could 'preserve' this thing. Then his sister, finally adjusting to the situation and realized its sorry state, called in the old women of the town and told them to bring their idol saints' old clothes then got to it. It took the priests longer to get here than the women to dress up the old body. Jo scrapped up its guts and stuffed them in as much as he could. Then his sister tagged in on his work and haphazardly stitched the fallen off parts with her needle. Right before the sun had set, the Godly carcass had fashioned itself into a proper image. It wore the clothes of a *Santo Niño*, donned the flower crown of Virgin Mary, and then had Jesus' gold halo stuck through its pliable skull. They all did this on the spot Jo had found the body. Barely touched until now, when the gentle fingers of the people here transformed it to look more like a Child of God.

They began calling that poor thing by that glorified name.

Jo's family kept the taxidermy for the night. They lived in the part of the town where the wind blew cold and the trees kept his roof cool. Jo himself was fine about it but Marian was still terrified of the Child and was regretting having to submit herself to the decisions of others. That woman was a coward. She couldn't handle being stared at from right across the room. Swore that thing blinked at her and started breathing and talking. She went a little sick in the head over the week this happened. Poor woman. She now screams at the sight of a lamb.

The next day the captain called in the parish once more so that they could bless the Child of God. This time the robed men were bright and early— got to the village before the sun could poke its crown out. And they brought their brothers and sisters with them. The whole-y entourage. Road Kill expected a few drops of holy water here and there on their shoddy craftsmanship but they got the entire ritual and everything. Turns out this whole ordeal was more serious than they initially thought it was. But that made the small population of Road Kill more maternal towards their little idol and who wouldn't? They lived their entire lives in a place known for blood and gore and the people from outside home named them after that same dirty thing. But all of a sudden, the sworn holy men of God start adoring their little craft. They raised it up high and paraded it from town to town. Now people don't call them Road Kill anymore. They're calling the locals *shepherds* now. What a sweet sounding name. They fawned over that new name of theirs.

Days have passed since the procession. The Pastures, formerly Road Kill because they can't associate such a dirty word for the sweet Child of God, became a holy site for pilgrims around the region. Death Row Acres had also lost its name. They now collectively call that part of land 'Gethsemane'. Like that same garden Jesus prayed in. Quite fitting. Marian had turned herself into a hermit but she calls herself a nun to look good in front of the devout. Jo stayed the captain. He kept himself mingling among the ranks of the priests, trying to dictate them like a good captain should but oftentimes they fall into deaf ears. As the season progressed, so did Marian's mental sickness. With her mind a little lost her brother took up on her supposed duty and became guardian of the site: Pampered the Child of God along with the rest of the Pasture locals. The days have been annoyingly bustling with foreign people coming in and out of their homes. It got worse when an old man dying of leprosy miraculously came back with a soft clear skin. "*All my wife had to do*

was bathe me with the cloth she used to wipe on the Child's forehead!" Suddenly everyone started doing it too. Miraculously, no one had gotten in an accident during all of these days. It made it harder to doubt the Child's miracles. The nights used to be quiet too before all this. Now everyone uses this solace to do rounds in the area while in prayer. The church eventually moves in and makes the captain's home their temporary parish where they'd bring in the Child inside the now insulated walls. The whole place crowds itself with everyone staying in lines for hours just to rub their handkerchiefs on the child's stitched neck. Oh the lines were unbelievable. The worst was during Mary's birthday. Though He wasn't the focus, they all seemed to believe that through association they'd get blessed even more.

But this fiasco only really lasted around a few months. It started when the season got dry and there were no rains to keep the heat from rising. A parish sister was praying by herself in the captain's living room when she swore she saw the Child blink. Now Marian at this point had been tucked away from the village. Only Jo ever really talks about her, let alone about her severely deteriorated mental state. So there had been no tales of fearmongering between the locals. The sister called in a priest but he dismissed her claim stating that the heat made her go mad. But then a churchgoer pointed it out too. He swore it looked at him while he was putting his hand over its head. And then another one said she heard a strange bleat from inside the hut. In less than a week the stories grew out of proportion. But instead of scaring off the devotees from praying, they prayed to it even harder. And those rumors traveled to places that the village didn't even know of. By the peak of September, the entire place was overflowing with people and it was more than the locals could handle. The priests stopped holding masses inside. The place was too crowded with pilgrims trying to get the essence of the Child on their cloths. Jo and the women that dressed the lamb in the first place couldn't even place their own hands on it. The heat inside was absolutely

unbearable. The first to catch the smell was the captain himself. Despite the turnaround, the roots of Road Kill never disappeared from him. He knew when something's dying. But no one believed his word.

For the past weeks, the Child of God was left unattended in the dry, over-populated air. It began falling apart bit by bit. First it was the flower crown that Jo's sister worked so hard to maintain. It dried up and shriveled. The smell got even worse. The stitches' threads quickly became undone as the inside began to bloat. The vest that once perfectly fit it looked like it only served as a wrap to hold it in from exploding. It even began leaking all over the captain's floor. He was furious.

The Child decomposed before hundreds and it took them up until its final moments to fully abandon it. They didn't leave when the flowers wilted. They didn't leave when it smelled. They only did so when the idol had become ugly and discolored. When it finally died down the captain couldn't even tell if its poor body could be salvaged unlike last time—back in the dawn of summer where only he had the eye and love for a mangled child. But this isn't his child anymore. Those 'believers' pet the poor kid too many times you could even consider it a beating. It's gone cold and dead. Rigor mortis was even there to prove it. Marian never got to say goodbye to their family's magnum opus. Jo simply told her what he'd now do with their work and she tearfully sighed. At least Marian could slowly come back to his senses now.

He looked left and right at the highway and checked for cars. He saw a glint of light from afar and threw the Child in the middle of the road. It's going to be bloody with all that air. But in time that gore would be mixed into the concrete of the highway rightfully earned and named Road Kill where it truly should have stayed.



Bleeding Blue

By Amber Colleen Oloya

When I turned thirteen, my Ninang gifted me a blue-jeweled rosary, intricately chained together in metal, with the image of Mama Mary as not the typical one, but that of Our Lady of Peñafrancia. At first, it was simply an ordinary religious gift that older people would typically give. I was not exactly excited when it was given to me; in fact for a thirteen year old, it was one of those gifts upon opening that made one's heart sink. One might think that rosary must have gone to my mother or simply displayed for its beauty behind the glass screens of our cabinet, but eventually, the blue-jeweled rosary found itself constantly in my hands and soon, in my pocket every single school day.

It was around the same time when I decided to make a promise of hope to myself: I will study college in Ateneo de Manila. Not just any Ateneo. It had to be *De Manila*. It was a dream founded amidst the desolate and monotonous life throughout the pandemic. During those times, my mother and I would attend virtual masses livestreamed by Ateneo de Manila's Radyo Katipunan, and I would find comfort in the Jesuits' inspiring homilies that gave me a glimpse of the prestigious yet compassionate way of life in Ateneo de Manila.

My mother would also tell me about her life when she was taking up her Master's Degree in Literature in Ateneo de Manila. She told me that every morning, she would jog around the campus's wide roads which were carefully lined with trees swaying in the light breeze. They blended with the university's intricate, tall buildings, perfectly lacing the summer sky from the sun's radiance. The green landscapes were engulfed in the modern city's stunning, glimmering lights, like a pocket of peace in the

busy and fast-paced city. One structure was eye-catching: the lofty church called the Gesu, which had a unique architecture and even had air conditioning inside. I imagined what life would be like for me studying college there, and attending Sunday masses in such a regal church. Life there naturally became a star-studded dream for me. But one detail struck me from my mother's stories: she never got to finish her Master's Degree there because she became too occupied with work. From then on, I had further reason to build towards my dream—it was not just mine, but also my mother's.

Ateneo was the propaganda I breathed my entire life. Ateneo was not new to me because I had been schooling in Ateneo de Naga since I was Grade 2—the very first time ADNU Grade School opened its doors. Even before then, I would run around the halls of ADNU Junior High School and play with the students and teachers there, because both my parents were teachers there themselves. They were the reason I had a 100% tuition scholarship all my entire ADNU life. Ever since I was seven until eighteen, those core Ignatian values of *Magis*, *Cura Personalis*, and mottos like *AMDG* and *Primum Regnum Dei* were repeated and lived everyday by heart. Even the Jesuit Communications songs and melodies were already injected into my bloodstream, especially the most ultimate Atenean prayer ever: St. Ignatius's Prayer for Generosity.

Being an Atenean was already an indistinguishable part of my own identity. Every day, my skirt's pocket would never not have the same blue rosary and a handkerchief, like your cliché Atenean. Perhaps every move was calculated by my parents towards that dream. Of course they had numerous students who had their success story of going from ADNU to ADMU, with all of them now so excellent in life. Once, while watching ADMU's graduation online together, my mother told me, "In around 6 years, you will be one of them too."

When I was a child, I thought Ateneo de Naga was directly connected to Ateneo de Manila under the same administration, like how the UP system works. I was ultimately proud of being an Atenean until I was eventually proven wrong, and the slow and embarrassing realization that Ateneo de Naga was one of the poorest Ateneos in the country just fueled me to desire for more. By the time I was in senior high school, I quickly grew sick of ADNU main campus's small perimeter and tight spaces. Every turn in that campus was nothing new, and I quickly memorized every spot, even the niche buildings where a senior high student should not be. Everyday, I daydreamed of the ADMU my mother described to me, with spacious fields and clean, intricate walls in the big city.

My point of entry to my dream university was a scholarship. As a HUMSS student, it was my only hope because every other generous scholarship was meant only for STEM students. It was natural for me to cling onto the hope and assurance that Ateneo de Manila's financial aid scholarship was benevolent and would surely award me, a needy but excellent student from the province. I knew ADMU was an elite school with a tuition fee we could only dream of being able to afford. To add to that, my mother was already retired and my father had only a year before retiring as well. Yet, my mother knew exactly what ADMU would be looking for, and so my parents shaped me into being the perfect candidate for that scholarship. Aside from the fact that I was needy enough for that scholarship, I also had to prove that I was worthy enough to claim and keep that scholarship. Thus, since 7th grade, my parents taught me that excellence in academics was not enough; I had to be good in extracurriculars too. I joined spelling bees and contests, performed music onstage, competed in debate tournaments, revived the school's literary folio, wrote songs, and served in every First Friday Mass. Extracurricular activities beyond the school's premises were also kept in

mind, so I learned to take part in outreach activities and be a youth leader for the whole city as a City Youth Official. Above all that, my grades were consistently stellar, almost always soaring at the top of the class. Everything was readily set in place for my application. All I had to do was wait and pray.

September 2024, I sat in the crowded Cathedral in front of Our Lady of Peñafrancia. Desperately, I prayed and prayed for just one thing: to be able to study in Ateneo de Manila for college. I religiously held my blue rosary and kept it inside my pocket everyday. Sometimes, that rosary would suddenly go lost, but I would eventually find it sitting somewhere around the house. One October day, I put a cheap blue ballpen in my pocket where my rosary was. In the jeep, the ballpen vomited its ink, and the blue rosary became eternally stained with further blue. It bled blue, as if it could not contain the blue within, and so it bled with its glory.

A few moments before the Ateneo College Entrance Test (ACET) results were released, I had a conversation with my work immersion supervisor, who asked me what my plans for college were. I told her of my ADMU dream, with UP as my second choice. I told her that my friends had already received the email of their ACET results, while I was fretting in pure anxiety, unable to think of anything else. After all, the decision to establish this dream I had my entire life was right about to be in front of my eyes.

When I opened my laptop, I saw that my mother messaged me that she stopped by the Basilica to pray for me. Many long minutes passed, when finally the email appeared in my inbox.

I passed the ACET with my first choice program!

I immediately jumped up from my chair and announced the news to the entire office of my work immersion, and my fellow intern jumped up and down with me in rejoice. Hallelujah, it felt like the Lord had risen! My parents were ever so proud of me. My excited mother told me to arrange things with the application for the dormitory inside the campus immediately. I told her it was all still closed, but she already contacted her friends regarding the dormitory processes.

However, my tower fell in the same office when the results of the financial aid scholarship popped up in my inbox. I stared at the email in confusion, my heart sinking slowly from the brief euphoria I just broke through. My tears began rolling down my cheeks, and I hopefully clung onto the chances of being rewarded still, after an appeal. It took me a few hard long minutes to realize that it was all over. In the background, the university gymnasium's loud speakers echoed until the office, playing an emotional Jesuit Communications song, "I Am Ever With You."

My mother told me it was God's sign to trust Him and a way for Him to tell me it was not all over. She promised me she would find a way no matter what. Yet when the dormitory registration form finally opened, I asked my mother what our decision was. She just told me to wait. Yet she eventually reasoned that if they were to fund my entire tuition in ADMU without scholarships, we would be one hospital bill away from drastic poverty.

Betrayal. Was God really ever with me? After all those prayers and hope-filled aspirations, I was robbed of the final key that would realize my dream. At this point, it felt like I was just guided into that dream to simply become a laughingstock.

I gave my father the silent treatment, because he kept on sending me UP propaganda videos and kept talking nonstop about how beautiful and

excellent UP was, while ADMU was “not that good.” I was furious at him because it felt like he was actively antagonizing my dream to study in Ateneo de Manila.

As for my mother, I thought she promised she would still find a way no matter what. I could not accept the radical change from entire support to lift me up towards that high, soaring tower up in the sky, and suddenly they would leave me there all alone, with no stairs nor ladder to safely get back down. Instead, they were wrecking its foundations, forcing me to fall down into the tower’s ruins in an impactful, bone-breaking thud.

After a lifetime of believing and building up towards that dream, it all ended so anticlimactically. I was so close. Where had I gone wrong? Everything in my application was crafted intricately since 7th grade. I was supposed to be the *perfect* candidate for that financial aid scholarship. It could have still been reasonable if I had been awarded at least 25% of that scholarship, but I received *nothing at all*. Was I not needy enough? Was I not excellent enough?

Everyday, I wept at the irreversible truth that faced me every morning I woke up, and at random moments of the day I would just *remember* and then suddenly burst into unending tears. It numbed me to the point I did not even leap and scream for joy when I opened my UPCAT results and got my first campus, first program choices. At this point, my blue rosary failed to end up in my pocket everyday. One day, I just found it on the laundry’s shelves, broken unevenly into two pieces. Its stain was still there, bleeding blue from the ink that tarnished it beautifully.

I felt jealous of my old friend Kim, who had the same dream as me. I was *accepted* into my first choice program, while he was *waitlisted*. He never had to exert effort to prove himself worthy by joining all those extracurricular activities. All he had to do was care about his studies. Yet

now, between the two of us, only Kim is studying in Ateneo de Manila because his parents have the money to support him. It was simply unfair that such prestigious education was actively being kept from the people who deserved and needed it most. They bait people into working hard for it but take it back once it is all so near, as if playing a prank. Yet I never blamed my parents for not having the money to support my studies in ADMU. No, I blamed the rich. I had been irrationally *furios* at the rich. This grief was a bone-breaking fall, from an identity and belief built for an entire lifetime. For such a long time, I cursed the rich and the Manileños from big rich high schools who were still given scholarships despite their abundance of resources. They always win in everything, because everything is just within their reach. They do not have to exert twice the effort to get into their dream school because they have the money. They do not have to worry and gamble their whole dream on an arbitrary scholarship system. Meanwhile, a hardworking girl from the poorest Ateneo in the country who worked so hard and clearly did not have enough financial power was still given *nothing at all*.

I did not want to go to UP because it was too different and unfamiliar as a liberal state university. Everyone intimidated me with the narratives about how the academics were so difficult that it was absolutely normal to fail tests here and there. They said that the tuition fee was free, but in exchange would be one's soul, so I worried about having enough time to stay sane at all and enjoy my life as a college student. I must admit, UP is indeed ruthless for its heavy workload and challenging exams that seem designed to intentionally make one fail, but at least now, I am surviving and even thriving here in UP. In fact, I have not failed an exam yet (I almost did, but hopefully I never will), but the people I know in ADMU have told of their failure stories early on in the semester. Things are not as bad as others have said. I have been enjoying my time here with all the different kinds of people I have met and spent time with. At least here in UP, I don't have to worry about having to fit in with the

majority, having to speak straight English to even be understood, or having to overthink if I am cool or funny enough to be accepted. Everyone is so diverse here that people mostly ignore each other's quirks and pieces of weirdness. In fact, all the glorious green landscapes my mother described in ADMU are symmetrical here in UP, but wider, more refreshing, and less suffocating. Studying here is difficult, but the joy of overcoming the challenges is more genuine and profound.

After a few months of the first semester of college came by, me and my friend Kim caught up. He told me about his life in Ateneo de Manila, how his classes were difficult to juggle, but he still enjoyed his college life, especially in his organizations. He told me about how he struggled to fit in, but there were events that welcomed him warmly with various generous freebies. He told me about the random but interesting classes he took as a fellow political science major. There was a pinch of pain in my heart upon knowing he had been living the life I once envisioned myself in, but I knew in my heart I was truly meant for UP.





One missed ball doesn't
define the match

Betrayal

By Giesha Niccaleigh Capistrano

I was living with what I thought was the best version of my life. I was in my fourth year at University of the Philippines, a dream that had finally become real after years of work and discipline. I was a student-athlete, a first libero, someone who trained through exhaustion and still managed to show up every day as if nothing inside me was breaking. A libero learns early that your job is to keep the ball from touching the floor no matter how hard the hit is. It is a role that demands constant reaction, no hesitation, no space for delay, only movement toward what is falling. Somewhere along the way, I think I started carrying that same instinct into my own life. I would throw myself toward situations that already felt like they were collapsing, as if stopping them was still part of my responsibility.

My life looked perfect. I aim to be the best libero in the collegiate league. That's why I train everyday just to look perfect in the eyes of a lot of people. I also receive a big allowance from our management, which reflects the hard work I put into training and the lifestyle I maintain as an athlete. I stay away from vices and remain focused on my goals, driven by the discipline that comes with constantly pushing myself to perform and improve. With this money, I get to buy everything that I want. The shoes, bags, and I just know that all of these came from my blood, sweat, and tears.

Even at home, my life felt arranged in a way that suggested stability because my mother and brother were in Canada while my father lived under his own mother's roof, and I had space and independence that made me feel like I was already becoming someone capable of holding her own life together. I even had a car left by my mother before she left,

and I treated it like proof that I was moving forward even when I did not fully understand where I was headed.

And then there was him, and from the outside, our relationship looked something secure and enviable because we had known each other since childhood and eventually grew from best friends into something I believed was built on trust and understanding, like a long practiced connection on the court where every pass and receive felt familiar because we had repeated the same rhythm for years.

For three years, we lived under the same roof, a truth I never told my family, and during the most exhausting parts of training when I barely recognized myself, he was the person I returned to because he felt like the only constant I had when everything else around me was already shifting. I mistook familiarity for safety. I thought I was standing in a secure rotation, believing I already knew where everyone around me would move next.

Then December 2025 came, and I remember being on my way to his game when something felt off in a way I could not explain, like the feeling before a serve when your body already reads where the ball is going even before it leaves someone's hand. Just like my body already knew something my mind had not accepted yet. When I arrived, he was waiting outside like he always did, and everything looked normal, but I remember feeling like I was already standing inside a version of my life that was about to change.

My friend Catherine could not meet my eyes, and she moved differently around me that day in a way that felt careful and restrained, as if she was carrying something she was not ready to release. I noticed it, but I told myself I was overthinking because I did not want to believe that anything in my life was shifting without me knowing.

I started making small conversations with her about her son, my godson who I treat like my own baby boy. I asked her about the game too, trying to catch up on everything I had missed throughout the day because it felt like I had stepped out of the rhythm of what was usually shared between us. I am always the one reaching out to start a conversation, because I know her well enough to know she is never usually like this around me. She is the type of person who naturally fills silence, who tells her stories without needing to be asked, like someone who controls the tempo of the rally between us. But this time it was different. The silence was on her side, and for the first time I was the one trying to keep the exchange going, while she stayed quiet in a way that felt unfamiliar and I was no longer the one anticipating her next move.

She kept looking at me during the game like she was waiting for a moment she could not avoid anymore, and when I finally asked her what was wrong, she told me to stay calm first before saying anything else. Then she told me everything.

Back in April 2025, my boyfriend had been meeting his ex, not just once but multiple times, and he had gone to her house with people I trusted deeply and treated like my own circle while at the same time he had been talking to her through Instagram notes in a quiet and consistent way as if nothing between us had changed.

What broke something in me was not only what he did but also what it meant. I felt like I had been diving for a ball everyone else had already watched hit the floor. Everyone knew except me, and my friends, the people around me, and I was the only one left outside of a truth that had already been living around me without my awareness.

This was not even the first time because he had done it before, and I had forgiven him, and I had even forgiven her, and I told myself that

forgiveness meant strength and that understanding meant love and that staying meant I was growing into a better version of myself.

But hearing it again made something inside me stop holding, not in a dramatic way but in a quiet and irreversible way. It felt like finally missing a ball I had spent years exhausting myself trying to save.

I smiled even though I was not okay, and I did not choose it because it was just what my body did when my mind could no longer process what I was hearing, and in that moment I felt like I was watching myself from a distance as if I was no longer fully inside my own life.

Then I walked out, and he followed me, asking what happened as if the answer was not already standing between us, and that was when everything came out of me all at once because I cried without stopping and asked him why and when and how, repeating questions that had no power to change anything anymore.

I knew I was falling apart in front of people, but I could not stop myself because the truth had nowhere left to go, until I did. It felt like being in the middle of a rally where I could no longer read the ball properly and my timing was already gone. I went quiet, turned away, and walked to the car because I could not stay inside that moment anymore, in that silence everything I had built started to rearrange itself without my permission. I was only left watching the shape of what I used to hold together.

Every choice I made for him, every time I placed him before myself, my family, and my own stability, came back to me at once, and I realized that I had been building my life around something I did not fully understand, as if I had been committing fully to a system I never truly saw the full play of. Even my achievements and discipline felt distant, like they belonged to someone I was no longer fully connected to, as

though I had stepped out of the rhythm I once trained so hard to maintain. We talked after that, and I made him repeat everything, every detail, every truth I had only heard from someone else, and he did, and in that confirmation it all became undeniable.

Then he explained himself by saying it belonged to the past and that nothing was happening anymore, and he asked for another chance while promising that he would change and cut off the people involved and fix what was broken between us. I stayed because I still wanted to believe that what we had could be repaired.

I set conditions instead of trust, and I told him that I would change too because I would question more and ask more and need more certainty when we were apart, and I told him he had to distance himself from the people connected to his ex. He agreed, so I stayed.

After that, I spent the holidays inside our house, and nothing looked different on the surface, but inside me everything kept shifting because I kept replaying everything and checking what I used to trust without thought while waiting for silence to turn into something I could no longer control. He kept reassuring me, but reassurance no longer felt like safety because it felt like repetition instead.

When training resumed, I was still physically present, but something had already changed in how I moved because I had lost weight without noticing and I was exhausted from nights of crying while overthinking even during practice as I tried to hold on to the version of myself I used to be.

I still showed up and still tried to perform, but I was no longer moving freely. A libero cannot hesitate, and I had started hesitating in everything. I was reacting a second too late, moving with a mind already somewhere

else. Because even during games I felt split between what I was doing and what I was thinking, and eventually I was taken out of the court.

I did not react immediately because it felt like something I had already expected without admitting it. Sitting off the court felt strangely familiar, like watching a game continue after realizing you were no longer part of the play.

Later, my mother messaged me and told me I did well, and I thanked her while apologizing at the same time because I could not explain what had changed inside me. She still knew me as someone who recovered quickly and returned to form, someone who had always found a way to stand back up after difficult moments. There were days when I wanted nothing more than to go back to her because I missed being her daughter more than being anything else. I missed the certainty that came with her presence and the comfort of feeling like someone else knew what to do when I no longer did.

But as much as I wanted to run toward her and place the weight of my decisions in her hands, I realized that I could not stay there forever. I had spent so much of my life holding onto people and situations as if they could tell me who I was supposed to become, and maybe that was why losing something felt like losing myself too.

My mother had always shown me strength, not through loud words or impossible expectations, but through the quiet way she continued moving forward even when life became difficult. I began understanding that strength was not simply enduring pain and pretending it had no effect on you. Sometimes strength meant knowing when to stop and understand what you were feeling before allowing those feelings to control your choices.

I still carry what happened with me because painful things do not disappear simply because we want them to. There are days when memories still return without warning and moments when doubt still arrives quietly, like a ball changing direction at the last second after you were certain you had already read the play correctly. Some things still catch me off guard, and there are moments when the impact feels familiar enough to bring me back to where I once was.

I started seeing things differently. I chose to stay because of the love I believed I had felt from him since the first time we met in 2022, a kind of connection that made me think I already understood where it was going. I told myself he could become a better man for me, someone who would treat me with care and never let me get hurt again, even if that belief was carrying more hope than certainty.

I no longer wanted every emotion to turn into an immediate decision. There were still moments when doubt and fear surfaced, and there were times when small things my boyfriend did would bring back pain I thought I had already set aside. But instead of allowing those feelings to consume me, I began communicating them to him. I wanted to understand my own thoughts before reacting and learn how to separate present actions from past wounds. At the same time, I wanted to consider his feelings and recognize that he was trying to become better after everything that had happened. I could see his efforts in the ways he tried to reassure me and rebuild the trust we had lost. Through all of this, I wanted to become someone who could look at life with a more mature perspective, someone who understood that heartbreak did not always require immediate answers and that uncertainty did not always mean everything was falling apart, not our relationship and not my life.

As a libero, I learned that not every ball can be received perfectly and not every play can be saved exactly the way you want it to be. Sometimes the ball leaves your platform unevenly, sometimes the point

is lost, and sometimes all you can do is prepare yourself for the next rally instead of remaining frozen in the last one.

Even that no longer feels like it used to. It is not confidence anymore but awareness, the kind that makes you move through everything more carefully because you know how quickly control can slip away.

But even in silence, I still wait for it to break again. Because once you have heard the sound of something hitting the floor when you thought someone would save it, you never stop listening for it.

I am beginning to understand that life moves that way too. It is noticing that your world continues moving even after something inside you breaks and realizing that one missed ball was never meant to define the rest of the game.

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a CW 10 group portfolio.

